A PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

CheckdIn

Meet someone interesting while you wait for your flight.

The problem

You are through security with time to spare. You sit alone at a coffee shop, a bar or a lounge, or read a magazine. The person at the next table might be exactly who you would enjoy talking to, but there is no easy way to know.

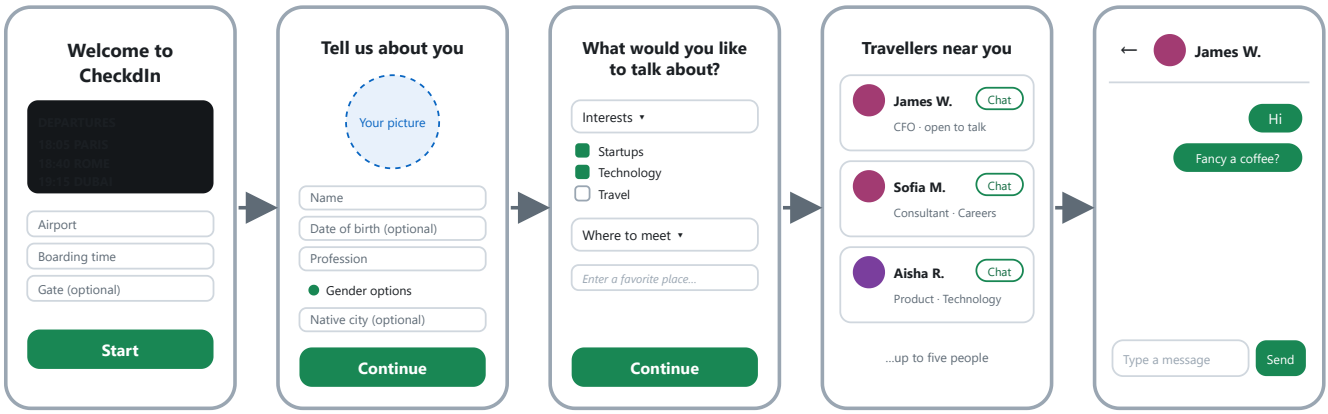
The idea

CheckdIn connects travelers who are at the **same airport**, boarding **around the same time**, with **things in common**. They say hello in a chat and agree on a cafe or bar to meet at.

Who it is for

Busy professionals who fly often: consultants, founders, investors and senior leaders. People who would happily use a spare hour to test an idea, learn about trends, or meet a like-minded stranger.

The journey: five screens



1 Welcome | 2 About you | 3 Interests | 4 Nearby | 5 Chat

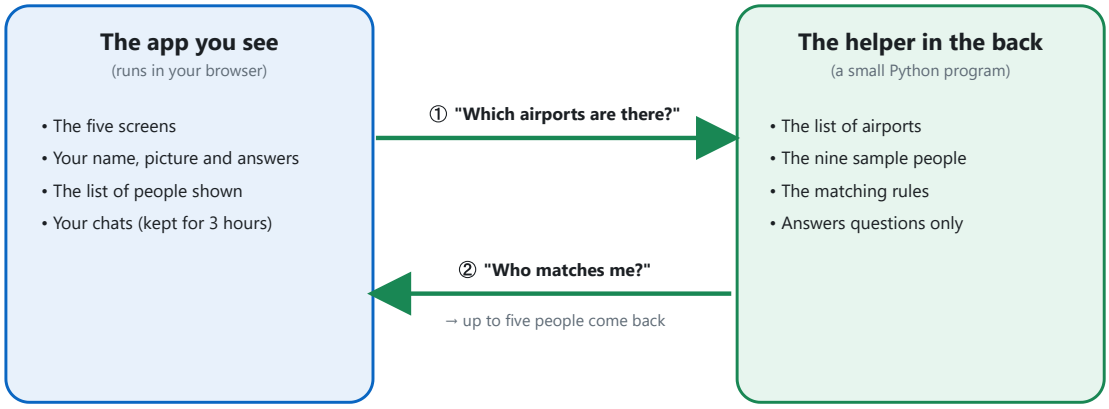
The seed of the idea

Think of a mango. The seed is what makes it a mango tree; the fruit grows around it. CheckdIn's seed is the **matching**: same airport, same time window, shared interests or a shared kind of place. The screens, colors and chat all grow around it.

BEHIND THE SCENES

Two programs, two conversations

CheckdIn is really two small programs running side by side. They only talk to each other twice.



Conversation ①: the airport list

When the Welcome screen opens, the app asks the helper for the list of airports. That is what fills the airport search box. The list has over three thousand airports, including London Heathrow.

Conversation ②: the matches

When you press Continue on the Interests screen, the app sends four facts to the helper: your **airport**, **boarding time**, **interests** and **kind of place**. The helper applies the rules and sends back up to five people.

A hotel front-desk way to picture it

You never call the helper directly. The app talks to its own "front desk", which passes anything starting with */api* on to the helper and hands the reply back. That keeps things simple: the browser only ever talks to one address.

Where does your information go?

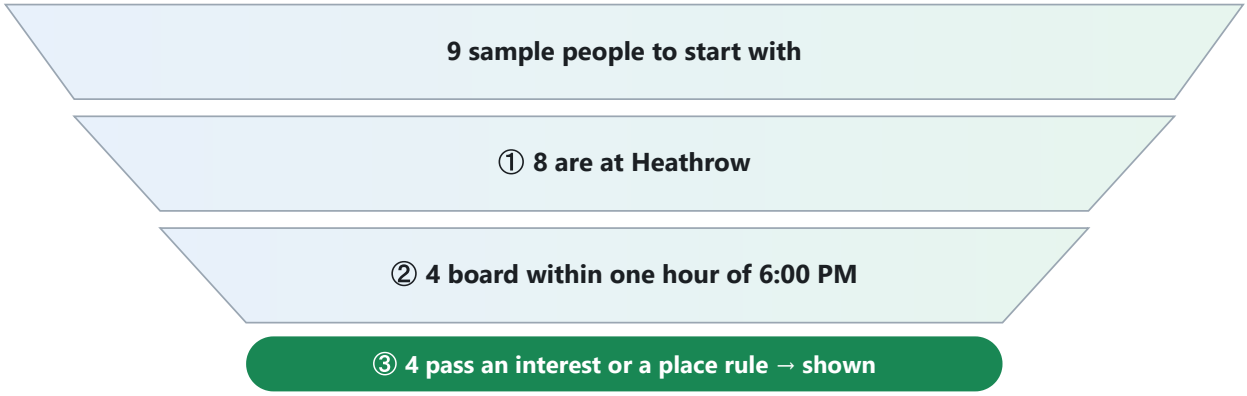
INFORMATION	WHERE IT LIVES	WHY
Name, picture, profession, gender, birthday, native city	Stays in your browser	Matching doesn't need them, so they are never sent.
Airport, boarding time, interests, kind of place	Sent to the helper	These are the only facts matching needs.
Your chats	Stays in your browser	Remembered for up to 3 hours, then forgotten.
Phone numbers, social profiles	Never asked for	You decide what to share once you meet in person.

THE SEED IN ACTION

How two strangers become a match

A match is decided by simple, checkable rules. Here is one real example.

Our traveler: at London Heathrow, boarding at **6:00 PM**, interested in **Startups**, happy to meet at a **Cafe**.



Shown, in this order

James · boards 6:05 PM | Sofia · 5:35 PM | Aisha · 6:40 PM | Daniel · 5:10 PM

Closest boarding time first. James and Aisha match on both interest and place; Sofia on place only; Daniel on interest only.

Left out, and why

Elena · in New York | Priya · 80 min earlier | Lucas · 75 min later | Mei · 110 min later | Tom · 3½ hours later

The three rules, in plain English

① **Same airport**. There is no point matching with someone at a different airport.

② **Within one hour**. Exactly 60 minutes apart counts; 61 does not.

③ **Something in common**. A shared interest *or* a shared kind of place is enough.

What counts as "in common": interests

- A shared interest.
- Either person is "just open to talk".
- Both like Startups, Technology or Markets (they overlap).

What counts as "in common": places

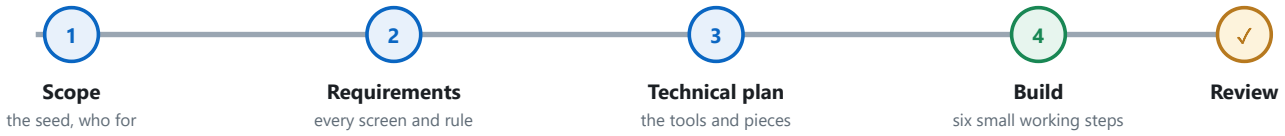
- Either person is happy with "any place".
- Both like Bar or Restaurant.
- Both like Cafe or Lounge.

Rules live in one small file, and 24 automatic tests check them.

HOW IT WAS MADE

Plan first, then build in small steps

Before any code existed, CheckdIn went through four planning documents. Each one made the idea more precise.



The six build steps, each one something you could try

- The Welcome screen, with its airport list
- The matching rules, tested on their own
- Interests, and the list of people
- The About You screen
- Chat, with a three-hour memory
- The README and a demo path

Every step was checked before the next began and saved as its own checkpoint.

What is real

- The screens and how they connect
- The matching rules and their ordering
- The helper program and its two conversations
- Chats that remember for three hours

What is pretend (on purpose)

- The nine people are fictional samples
- They don't reply in chat
- Nobody else is using the app at the same time
- No sign-in, no saved profiles

Where it could go next

- **Real people** finding each other live, which needs a shared place to keep everyone's details.
- A **request and accept** step before a chat opens.
- **Safety** tools such as blocking and reporting, and **meetups for three or more**.
- **Real flight checks** and real venues at each airport.

One habit worth keeping

Every requirement was written so it could be **checked**. "Within one hour" became "60 minutes is in, 61 is out", and that is now an automatic test. Write down what you will *see* when something works, and you can trust the result.

Photo credit on the Welcome screen: Marek Ślusarczyk, CC BY 3.0 · Airport data: OurAirports